in history between the reigning Chinese empire and one or the other Korean kingdoms, but Korea retained its independent identity while paying ritual homage to the Chinese emperor. It was only during 1910–45 that Korea was occupied by Japanese forces and made a colony.

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By contrast, Indian cultural influence, spread over a much larger area, shaped political thought and institutions, religious beliefs, language and literature, and art and culture in general. Both mainland Asia (or Indo-China) and maritime Asia (South-East Asia) were also home to large and powerful empires which derived their inspiration from India. These include the Funan, the first great empire of South-East Asia (second to seventh centuries CE), succeeded by the Khmer empire, both covering much of present-day Cambodia, Thailand, Laos and part of southern Vietnam (ninth to fifteenth centuries CE). The Srivijaya (seventh to thirteenth centuries) and the Mahapajit (thirteenth to sixteenth centuries) empires, centred on the Indonesian archipelago, also drew their inspiration from India, as did the Champa empire, which at its maximum extent stretched from what is now middle Vietnam to southern Vietnam. These empires used Sanskrit as the court language, promoted the Hindu cults of Shiva and Vishnu, adopted Hindu rituals and even adopted Sanskrit names for the rulers. Indian concepts of kingship, of ‘Cakravartin’, became the instruments of political legitimization.

Little is known about the Funan empire beyond what is contained in Chinese records. We know that it was centred on the delta of the Mekong River, with its capital at Vyadhapura. It dominated the maritime trade between India and China, China and South-East Asia, and India and South-East Asia. It was the first of the ‘Sanskritized’ kingdoms of South-East Asia. Its culture and language were brought to the country by Indian traders, whose large presence is testified to by the Chinese records. In a Chinese royal chronicle of 503 CE , the king of Funan is described as ‘the leader of all Nanyang (the Southern Ocean)’. It is interesting to note that Indian and, later, Arab sailing ships, which used to call at the ports in South-East Asia,